The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: AFP via Getty Images

One of the **Trump administration's** top officials resigned in protest against the **Iran war**. Joe Kent, who served as the national **counterterrorism** chief, said in his resignation letter that he could not "support sending the next generation off to fight and die" in a pointless war, as Iran posed "no imminent threat" to America. He blamed Donald Trump's involvement on "pressure from Israel".

Israel's defence minister said that **Ali Larijani**, secretary of Iran's Supreme National Security Council, had been killed in a targeted strike. He was the most public face of the regime, and had been running the nuclear negotiations with America. Iran has not commented yet. Seperately, Israel said it also killed **Gholamreza Soleimani**, head of the Islamic Revolutionary Guard's Basij militia.

Mr Trump said he no longer needed help from NATO allies in his Iran war. Several countries ruled out participation (including Germany, Italy, Spain and Canada) or said they had no plans to send warships (Australia, France and Japan) to help unblock the Strait of Hormuz. "They should've been there," the president said at a White House press briefing. He also called NATO's decision "a foolish mistake".

Russia signalled it was prepared to back **Cuba** after Mr Trump said he would be "taking" the island "in some form". Russia's foreign ministry said it "strongly condemn[ed] attempts of gross interference" in the country's affairs. The *New York Times* earlier reported that the Trump administration, which is in talks with Cuban officials, is seeking to oust Miguel Díaz-Canel, the president.

Volodymyr Zelensky arrived in London for talks with Britain's prime minister, Sir Keir Starmer, and the head of NATO, Mark Rutte. Ukraine's president is expected to sign a new defence pact with Britain, mainly to supply more drones to his country. As the Iran war occupies global leaders, Mr Zelensky is touring Europe to draw attention to his country's continued fight with Russia, now in its fourth year.

Sri Lanka's government said that public institutions would no longer work on Wednesdays to save energy. Asian countries, which consume more than 80% of the oil and gas that crosses the Strait of Hormuz, are cutting back their usage. **Thailand** asked workers to wear breezier clothes in offices to cut air-conditioning; **Myanmar** has banned cars from roads on alternate days to reduce petrol use.

Arizona's attorney-general charged **Kalshi**, a prediction market, with running an illegal gambling operation in the state and accepting bets on future elections, including the 2028 presidential race. It is the first time a state has charged Kalshi with criminal activity, although other state regulators have sought to limit its operations. The Trump administration has been lenient with prediction markets. Kalshi called the case "paper thin".

Figure of the day: 5%, the proportion of the global fleet of product tankers currently stuck in the Gulf.

Photograph: Reuters

Is Israel ready for a long war?

Over the weekend Semafor, a news site, reported that Israel's stocks of ballistic-missile interceptors may be "running critically low". The claim drew fierce denials from Israeli officials, who insisted the country was prepared for "prolonged combat".

But its supplies are surely being tested: Iran, which was thought to have around 2,500 ballistic missiles at the start of the war, has already launched hundreds. Our analysis suggests Gulf states—which say they have taken out some 800 Iranian missiles and 2,500 drones—are burning through their interceptor stocks. And Iran is insisting more attacks are coming: on Monday it repeated threats that it would start targeting American companies in the Gulf soon. The precise number of remaining interceptors and missiles on each side remains a closely guarded secret. The war's length could be determined in part by whose stocks hold out longest.

Photograph: AP

Britain’s chancellor’s pitch for growth

Rachel Reeves set out her vision for Britain’s economy in a speech. Official forecasters expect the economy to grow by just 1.1% in 2026. As Labour languishes in the polls, the chancellor tried to reassure sceptics that she has a credible plan.

Her speech covered three themes. First, Mr Reeves said that Labour wants closer ties with Europe, although she rules out any changes that might make a serious difference, including rejoining the customs union. Second, Ms Reeves said the government will invest £2.5bn ($3.3) in AI and quantum computing. Britain has a compelling pitch on safety but has struggled to find its footing in an arena dominated by America and China.

And finally, Ms Reeves suggested that regional mayors could be given some tax revenues to spend on their own local priorities. But volatile oil and gas prices, thanks to the war in the Middle East, will do more to shape Labour’s political future than the chancellor’s words.

Photograph: Getty Images

Havana’s Hail Mary

America’s Cuban exiles will soon be allowed to invest in the private sector, own property and start their own businesses in their motherland for the first time in six decades. A new “fluid commercial relationship” with American companies and the Cuban-American community is expected to be announced in the coming days.

The decision is a desperate pivot. Venezuela had been a primary source of subsidised oil for Cuba. That changed overnight when America kidnapped Venezuela’s leader, Nicolás Maduro, and then blocked oil shipments to the island. The resulting electricity crisis has left some 10m Cubans without power.

The Trump administration has warned that the island’s government “is going to fall pretty soon” unless it reaches a deal. On Monday America’s president said that he would have “the honour” of taking Cuba, and doing “anything [he] wants with it”. Cubans in America, who have long supported America’s sanctions in the hope that they may accelerate regime change, may now find their loyalties split.

Photograph: Getty Images

The Irish example for minority languages everywhere

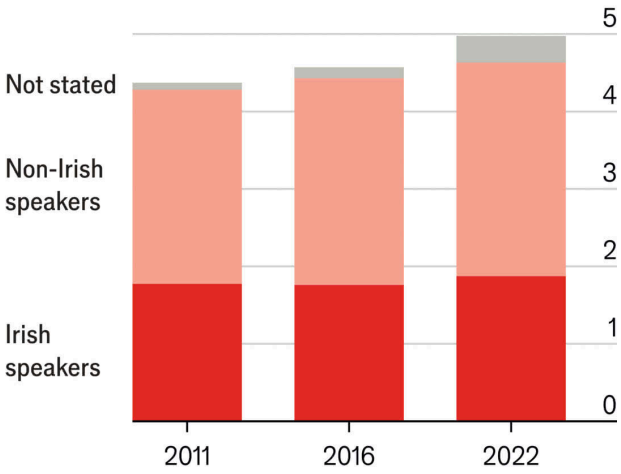
Tuesday is St Patrick's Day, and Ireland has much to celebrate. Its ancient language is experiencing a remarkable revival. A century ago just 18% of Ireland's population spoke Irish; UNESCO has declared it "definitely endangered". Today roughly 40% of Ireland's population (some 1.9m people) speak Irish—a 71% increase from 1991.

The shift reflects something difficult to measure: Irish has become cool. Irish actors such as Cillian Murphy and Paul Mescal have spoken Irish on the world stage, while Kneecap, an Irish-language hip-hop group, has earned global recognition. Irish-speaking social-media influencers have made the language a fixture of everyday life.

State policy has helped, too. The government has set a 20% recruitment quota for Irish speakers in the public sector by 2030; Irish has been an official working language in the European Union since 2022. Being an English-speaking country in the bloc has helped Ireland prosper. But Irish makes it Irish, even if few people speak it daily.

The state of Irish

Ireland, population aged 3 and over, m



Source: Central Statistics Office

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 GMT on Friday to . We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Tuesday: The Bellman is a key character in which Lewis Carroll poem?

Monday: Which character is portrayed by Sigourney Weaver in the Alien films?

No society can surely be flourishing and happy, of which the far greater part of the members are poor and miserable.

Adam Smith